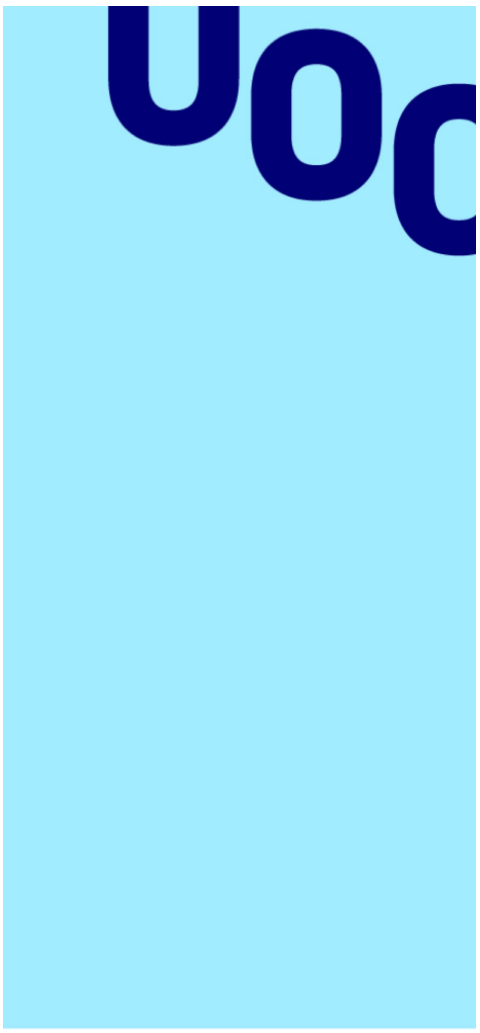
Comparative Evaluation of Satellite Image Segmentation Methods for Coastline Extraction: Spectral Indices vs. Deep Learning.



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Area 4: Pattern Recognition and Computer Vision in Applied Sciences - Geographic Information Systems, satellite images and geopositioning

MSc in Data Science

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April 26, 2026

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Final Work Card

Title of the work:	Comparative Evaluation of Satellite Image Segmentation Methods for Coastline Extraction: Spectral Indices vs. Deep Learning.
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Date of delivery:	April 26, 2026
Studies or Program:	MSc in Data Science
Area of the Final Work:	Area 4: Pattern Recognition and Computer Vision in Applied Sciences - Geographic Information Systems, satellite images and geopositioning
Language of the work:	English
Keywords:	Earth Observation, Satellite imagery, Coastal Remote Sensing, Semantic Segmentation, Spectral Indices, Water Segmentation

Abstract

A maximum of 250 words, detailing the purpose, context of application, methodology, results and conclusions of the work.

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Chapter 1

Introduction

1.1 Context and Justification of Work

Coastal regions are among the most dynamic, densely populated, and socio-economically vital areas on Earth. However, these environments are under constant threat from both natural processes and anthropogenic pressures, exacerbated by climate change. As sea levels rise and extreme weather events become more frequent, coastal erosion has emerged as a critical global challenge. Consequently, accurate and continuous monitoring of shoreline position (the instantaneous interface between land and water) is essential for understanding morphological changes, evaluating erosion trends, and planning effective coastal defense strategies.

Historically, tracking shoreline evolution relied on in-situ topographic surveys or aerial photogrammetry. While highly accurate, these methods are often prohibitively expensive, labor-intensive, and limited in spatial and temporal coverage. In recent decades, the advent of Earth Observation (EO) satellites has revolutionized coastal surveying. Missions such as the European Space Agency's (ESA) Sentinel-2 offer free, high-frequency, and multi-decadal imagery spanning the entire globe (Vitousek et al., 2023). This wealth of optical satellite data allows researchers and coastal managers to monitor shoreline dynamics at unprecedented scales and at a fraction of the cost.

To extract the exact position of the waterline from a satellite image, traditional methodologies rely heavily on Spectral Indices. These mathematical formulas exploit the differences in how water and land reflect specific bands of sunlight (such as the near-infrared) to create binary masks separating water from non-water. Frameworks utilizing these principles, such as CoastSat (Vos et al., 2019b), SHOREX (Sánchez-García et al., 2020), and CASSIE (Almeida et al., 2021), have become the operational standard for generating automated, large-scale shoreline extraction data worldwide, providing an efficient alternative to manual digitization.

However, this traditional pixel-by-pixel approach faces severe limitations when applied to highly dynamic, macrotidal environments. In high-energy coasts with large tidal ranges (such as the Cantabrian Sea) the presence of extensive wet sand and breaking wave foam creates a persistent "semantic ambiguity". The basic spectral premise that water strongly absorbs light while land

reflects it frequently breaks down in these transition zones, leading to severe misidentifications of the actual waterline (see Figure 1.1). As demonstrated by recent studies (e.g., Cabezas-Rabadán et al., 2026), traditional tools struggle to navigate these challenging coastal scenes, resulting in significant spatial errors.

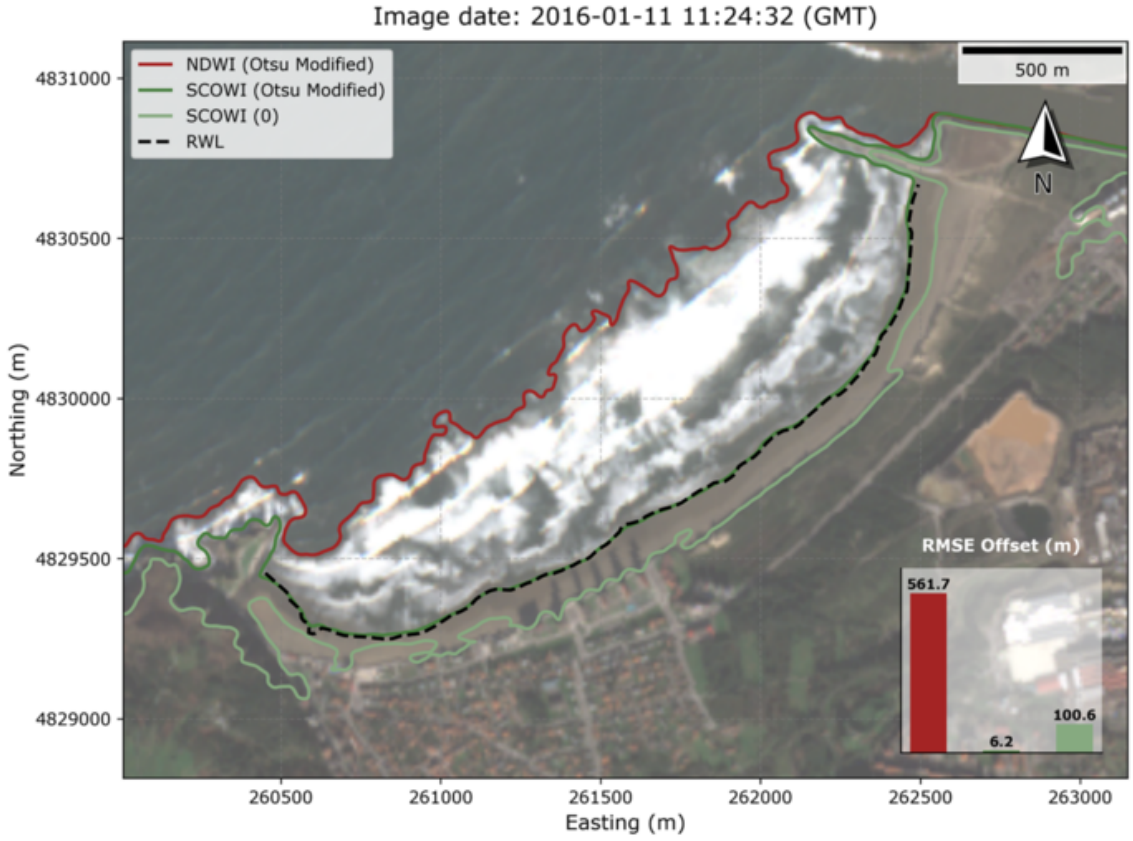


Figure 1.1: Examples of shoreline misidentification in a macrotidal beach (adapted from Cabezas-Rabadán et al., 2026)

Consequently, there is a clear and urgent need to move beyond purely spectral formulas and explore methodologies capable of understanding the context of the image. Deep Learning (DL), a subset of Artificial Intelligence (AI), offers a promising solution to bridge this gap. Unlike traditional index thresholds that evaluate the reflectance value of an isolated pixel, advanced DL semantic segmentation architectures can learn complex spatial patterns, textures, and contextual hierarchies. By emulating how the human eye interprets a satellite image (recognizing the texture of a wave or the gradient of wet sand) DL models hold the potential to overcome the spectral confusion inherent in macrotidal environments.

1.2 Work Objectives

Given the challenges posed by macrotidal coasts and the limitations of traditional spectral methods, the overarching goal of this Master's Thesis is to evaluate the operational viability of Deep Learning solutions for shoreline mapping. To ensure a robust assessment, the study will focus on three highly dynamic beaches located along the northern Spanish coast: Salinas (Asturias) and El Puntal (Cantabria).

Primary Objective:

- To perform a comprehensive benchmarking analysis between traditional spectral-based thresholding (e.g., NDWI, MNDWI) and modern Deep Learning-based semantic segmentation for automated coastline extraction in complex coastal environments.

Secondary Objectives:

- To generate a high-quality "Ground Truth" dataset of coastal masks (classifying pixels into *water*, *white-water*, *wet sand*, and *sand*). This dataset will be used exclusively to train and validate the Deep Learning segmentation models, and will be rigidly constructed through manual photo-interpretation, utilizing AI-assisted annotation tools (such as the Segment Anything Model, SAM (Kirillov et al., 2023)) solely to refine and accelerate the process.
- To generate a high-quality "Ground Truth" dataset of photo-interpreted waterlines directly derived from the Sentinel-2 imagery. This dataset will serve primarily to benchmark the accuracy of the extracted waterlines (testing both traditional spectral indices-based models and Deep Learning segmentation models).
- To systematically evaluate and compare the performance degradation of both classical indices and Neural Networks under specifically adverse oceanographic and atmospheric conditions (e.g., the presence of extensive white foam, variations in intertidal sand moisture, and partial cloud cover).

1.3 Impact on Sustainability, Ethics-Social and Diversity

In compliance with the UOC's cross-disciplinary competence "Ethical and global commitment", this section identifies the positive and/or negative impacts of the Master's Thesis on the three dimensions: Sustainability, Ethical Behavior and Social Responsibility, and Diversity and Human Rights.

1. Sustainability
The project uses freely available Sentinel-2 Level-2A imagery from the Copernicus program and performs all processing either locally or on an institutional computing cluster. Traditional field-based coastal monitoring requires repeated physical surveys with vehicles, boats or aircraft,

generating higher operational GHG emissions. The Deep Learning training phase incurs moderate energy consumption inherent to GPU usage; however, this is limited in scope and offset by the elimination of on-site campaigns. No other significant negative environmental impacts (resource depletion, waste generation or large-scale land use) are identified.

Overall impact: neutral to slightly positive.

2. Ethical Behavior and Social Responsibility (RS)
All data used are open-access satellite products with no personal, sensitive or identifiable information. Ground-truth masks were generated through manual photo-interpretation assisted only by the Segment Anything Model for refinement. Model performance is evaluated with transparent metrics (IoU, Dice, geometric error) and limitations under adverse conditions (foam, wet sand, clouds) are explicitly quantified and reported. The project does not produce automated decisions affecting individuals or communities. Potential risk of misinterpretation of shoreline outputs by end-users is mitigated by providing full error analysis.

Overall impact: neutral.

3. Diversity and Human Rights
The thesis is strictly technical and involves no human subjects, personal data, biometric information or gender-related variables. Development was carried out individually with no team composition. The resulting code, models and documentation use objective technical language and do not contain implicit biases. No positive or negative impacts on human rights, gender diversity or vulnerable groups are identified.

Overall impact: neutral.

1.4 Focus and Method Followed

The methodology is structured into four main phases as illustrated in the workflow diagram (Figure 1.2):

1. **Data Acquisition:** Downloading Sentinel-2 Level-2A (atmospherically corrected) products from Google Earth Engine, covering the period 2015–2025. A built-in cloud detection algorithm will be applied as an initial filter to discard obstructed scenes, utilizing the remaining available cloud-free images.

2. **Preprocessing & Labelling:** Calculation of spectral indices (NDWI, MNDWI). Generation of Ground Truth masks using the Segment Anything Model (SAM) through an interactive annotation tool (Bhattiprolu, 2026). Generation of Ground Truth coastline vectors through manual photo-interpretation of RGB composites derived from Sentinel-2 images.

3. **Model Implementation:**

    - *Baseline:* Automatic thresholding methods applied to spectral indices.

- *Deep Learning:* Training semantic segmentation models like U-Net (Ronneberger et al., 2015) or SegFormer (Xie et al., 2021). Model training will be run locally on an NVIDIA RTX 3060 GPU, with an institutional computing cluster (2 nodes, 2x NVIDIA A30 each) available for scaling if required.

4. **Evaluation:** Comparison using pixel-based metrics (IoU, Dice) and geometric validation (calculating the mean Euclidean distance between the predicted and real coastline).

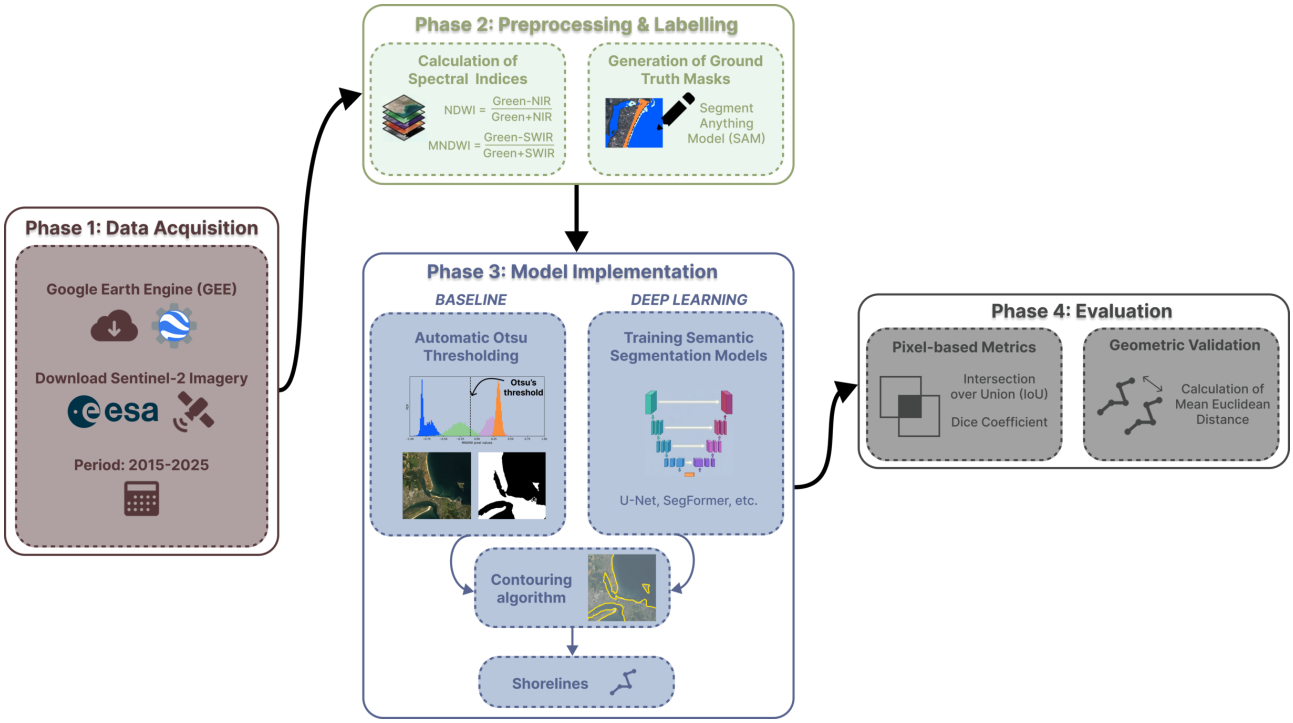


Figure 1.2: Schematic representation of the methodological workflow.

1.5 Work Schedule

The project is planned to be developed over a 5-month period (including the thesis defence), structured into the following tasks as shown in the Gantt chart (Figure 1.3). Additionally, project management software such as Trello or MS Planner will be used to track and control the tasks at a more specific level:

- **Task 1:** Literature review, selection of study sites (beaches), and satellite images download.
  - Literature review on traditional methods for satellite-derived coastline extraction.
  - Literature review on Deep Learning models applied to coastal monitoring.
  - Satellite images download for northern Spanish coast beaches: Salinas (Asturias) and El Puntal (Cantabria).

- **Task 2:** Calculation of spectral indices and generation of Ground Truth datasets.
  - Preparation of the GitHub repository structure for the project's codebase.
  - Calculation of spectral indices (e.g., NDWI, MNDWI).
  - Create RGB composites to assist in the annotation process.
  - Ground Truth generation through manually photo-interpretation of the RGB composites.
  - Generation of Ground Truth coastline vectors directly from the Sentinel-2 images, to be used for benchmarking.
- **Task 3:** Model implementation: Development of baseline and Deep Learning architectures.
  - Application of automatic thresholding to spectral indices to set baseline models.
  - Selection, development, and training of Deep Learning architectures.
  - Application of contouring algorithms to extract shorelines at sub-pixel precision.
- **Task 4:** Statistical analysis of results, benchmarking across different algorithms, and final evaluation.
  - Pixel-based metrics evaluation (e.g., IoU, Dice Coefficient).
  - Geometric validation by calculating the mean Euclidean distance between predicted and real shorelines.
  - Comparison of performance under adverse conditions (foam, wet sand) and transferability assessment.
- **Task 5:** Drafting report and interim deliveries.
- **Task 6:** Progress meetings with directors.

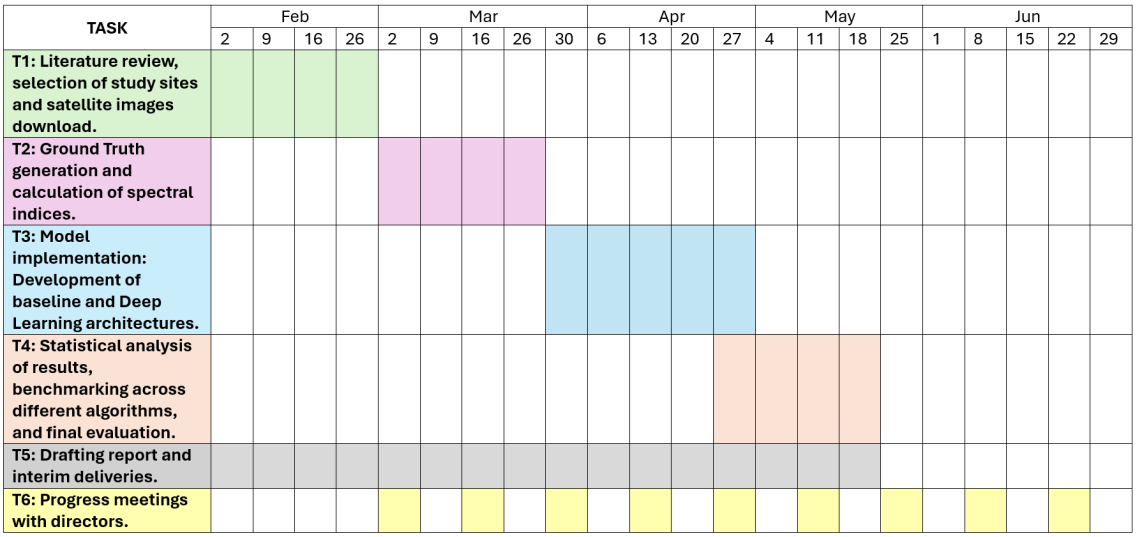


Figure 1.3: Gantt chart of the project timeline.

1.6 Brief Summary of Products Obtained

TO BE WRITTEN

1.7 Brief Description of Other Memory Chapters

TO BE WRITTEN

1.8 Statement on the Use of Generative Artificial Intelligence

TO BE WRITTEN

Chapter 2

State of Art

2.1 Coastal Monitoring and Shoreline Definition

The analysis of shoreline evolution over time is a fundamental aspect of coastal science, engineering, and management. An idealized definition of the shoreline describes it as the physical interface between land and water (Boak and Turner, 2005). However, this boundary is highly dynamic, driven by continuous fluctuations in water levels caused by tides, waves, storm surges, and seasonal changes. Consequently, capturing a single, definitive shoreline position is practically impossible, making it necessary to define the shoreline based on specific objectives and available data.

To overcome this, researchers typically rely on *shoreline indicators*, which serve as proxy features to represent the true shoreline position. According to the comprehensive review by Boak and Turner (2005), these indicators are generally grouped into two main categories:

- **Visually discernible features**: Physical marks left on the coast, such as the High-Water Line (HWL) (often identified by a change in sand color due to moisture content), the instantaneous wet/dry boundary left by wave runup, or the seaward edge of dune vegetation (Figure 2.1).
- **Tidal datum-based indicators**: These define the shoreline as the intersection of a specific coastal profile with a predetermined vertical elevation, such as Mean High Water (MHW) or Mean Sea Level (MSL). While datum-based indicators provide a mathematically objective boundary, they often require high-resolution topographic data (e.g., DGPS or LiDAR) which can be hard to acquire for long-term or large-scale studies (Figure 2.1).

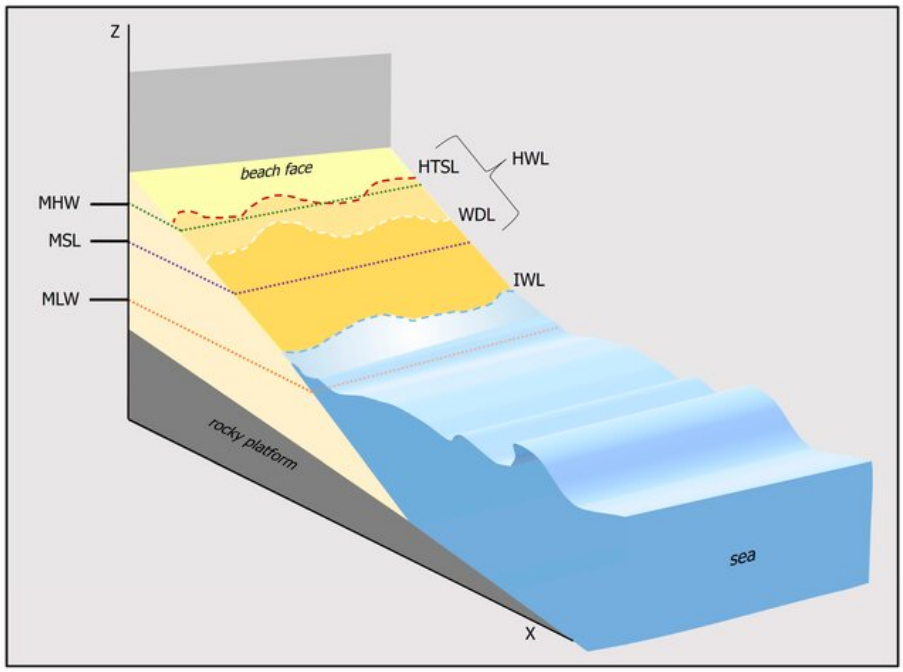


Figure 2.1: Schematic representation of a beach profile illustrating shoreline indicators.(1) Feature based, detected on beach face: HTSL—high-tide swash line; WDL—wet–dry line; HWL—high-water line; IWL—instantaneous water line. (2) Elevation-based: MHW—mean high-water, MSL—mean sea level; MLW—mean low-water. (Source: Valverde et al., 2025)

The selection of a specific indicator and monitoring frequency depends on the intended application of the data. Shoreline monitoring serves several critical functions:

- *Long-term Trend Analysis*: Quantifying multi-decadal erosion or accretion rates to understand coastline evolution.
- *Storm Impact Assessment*: Evaluating episodic erosion caused by extreme weather events and tracking the subsequent post-storm recovery.
- *Seasonal Variability Studies*: Capturing the cyclical movement of the shoreline due to changing wave climates between summer and winter.
- *Coastal Management*: Quantifying the dry beach width for coastal management purposes, such as evaluating the beach's natural potential to act as a coastal defense against storms, assessing its carrying capacity for tourism and recreational activities, and informing strategies to mitigate overall vulnerability.

Within this theoretical framework, it is essential to define the specific indicator addressed in this research. This Master's Thesis focuses exclusively on the instantaneous waterline (WL), defined as the precise boundary between the water body and the emerged land at the exact moment of satellite overpass. While the term *shoreline* is often used in a broader sense in coastal literature, throughout this document, both *shoreline* and *waterline* (or the acronym SDW for

Satellite-Derived Waterline) are used interchangeably to refer specifically to this instantaneous land-water interface. Focusing on the WL is particularly relevant for satellite-based monitoring, as it represents the most direct feature discernible from optical imagery, although its detection in macrotidal environments remains a significant technical challenge, as will be described in more detail in Section 2.5.

2.2 Traditional Coastal Monitoring Methods

Historically, coastal monitoring has relied heavily on in-situ physical surveys. While these methods can offer high precision, they are inherently constrained by significant logistical effort, high operational costs, and consequently, low spatial and temporal coverage.

Topobathymetric monitoring using Global Navigation Satellite Systems (GNSS), particularly those operating in Real-Time Kinematic (RTK) mode, have been widely employed to acquire cross-shore beach profiles (Morton et al., 1993). Although GNSS-based techniques can achieve millimeter-level accuracy, data collection is limited to the physical path traversed by operators (e.g., walking, driving, or mounted on a vehicle), making continuous shoreline mapping over regional scales largely impractical.

To bridge the spatial gap of ground surveys, researchers increasingly turned to advanced airborne scanning technologies such as Light Detection and Ranging (LiDAR). Airborne LiDAR allows for the rapid acquisition of dense, high-resolution 3D point clouds over hundreds of kilometers of coast, from which datum-based shorelines can be extracted objectively (Stockdon et al., 2002). However, the high economic cost of instrument deployment restricts its use to infrequent, opportunistic, or project-specific flights, failing to provide the high-frequency temporal data necessary for continuous monitoring.

Addressing the temporal limitations of physical surveys, fixed coastal video monitoring systems (most notably the Argus system (Holman et al., 1993)) were developed in the 1990s. These ground-based camera networks capture high-frequency images (e.g., every 10 minutes) and can produce time-averaged images to derive robust shoreline-proxy indicators. While providing excellent temporal resolution to track short-term morphological changes, their spatial coverage remains inextricably confined to the camera's visual field of view (typically 1–3 kilometers), leaving vast stretches of the coastline unmonitored.

More recently, the rise of ubiquitous smartphone technology has catalyzed the development of Citizen Science approaches for coastal monitoring, best exemplified by the global CoastSnap project (Harley and Kinsela, 2022). By installing simple, low-cost smartphone cradles at strategic coastal viewpoints, these initiatives crowdsource beach imagery from the general public. While this drastically reduces both initial deployment and operational costs while providing data with a spatial resolution similar to video stations, the temporal frequency and reliability of the data are inherently opportunistic, depending entirely on community participation and favorable weather conditions.

To overcome the inherent trade-offs between spatial coverage, temporal frequency, and operational costs present in these traditional methods, researchers have increasingly turned to

Earth Observation (EO) satellites. As summarized in Table 2.1, satellite imagery uniquely provides continuous, global-scale coverage with a high frequency of observations at virtually zero operational cost for the end-user, effectively resolving many of the historical monitoring limitations. The application of this remote sensing data for continuous shoreline extraction, which is the cornerstone of this thesis, will be discussed in detail in the following section (Section 2.3).

Table 2.1: Summary of common coastal monitoring methods and their key characteristics.

Monitoring Method	Spatial Scale	Spatial Resolution	Temporal Resolution	Operational Cost
GNSS / RTK Topography	Local	Millimetric	Low (Infrequent)	Very High (per survey)
Airborne LiDAR	Regional	Sub-meter	Low (Infrequent)	Very High (per flight)
Video systems (Argus)	Local (1-3 km)	Centimetric	Very High (Minutes)	Low (after initial setup)
Citizen Science (CoastSnap)	Local	Centimetric	Highly Variable	Very Low
Optical satellites (i.e. Landsat 4-9 and Sentinel-2)	Global	Decametric (10 m)	High (Days)	Zero (Free open data)

2.3 Satellite Remote Sensing for Coastal Monitoring

The advent of Earth Observation (EO) satellites has profoundly democratized and revolutionized coastal monitoring, effectively resolving the historical trade-offs between spatial coverage and temporal frequency. The cornerstone of this revolution is the Landsat program, jointly managed by NASA and the USGS. Initiated in the 1970s and providing continuous 30-meter resolution optical imagery since the launch of Landsat 4 in 1982, it offers an unparalleled, retrospective archive spanning over four decades. This extensive catalog allows coastal scientists and managers to reconstruct long-term shoreline evolution, analyze multi-decadal erosion trends, and assess the historical impact of major climatic events on a truly global scale.

Building upon this legacy, the European Space Agency (ESA) catalyzed a new era in EO with the launch of the Copernicus Sentinel-2 constellation. Initially a twin-satellite system (Sentinel-2A and 2B, launched in 2015 and 2017), the constellation has recently been reinforced with the launch of Sentinel-2C in September 2024. Sentinel-2 dramatically bridged the gap to traditional in-situ methods by providing freely available, multispectral imagery at an unprecedented 10-meter spatial resolution (in visible and Near-Infrared bands) with a high-frequency revisit time of just 5 days at the equator (Vitousek et al., 2023). This exponential leap in temporal resolution has unlocked the ability to monitor highly dynamic, short-term coastal processes from space, such as seasonal beach profile fluctuations (e.g., Warrick et al., 2025) and the acute morphodynamic impacts of specific storms (e.g., Cabezas-Rabadán et al., 2024). The synergistic combination of both Landsat and Sentinel-2 missions has sparked an exponential growth in satellite-derived shoreline research over the last decade (Figure 2.2).

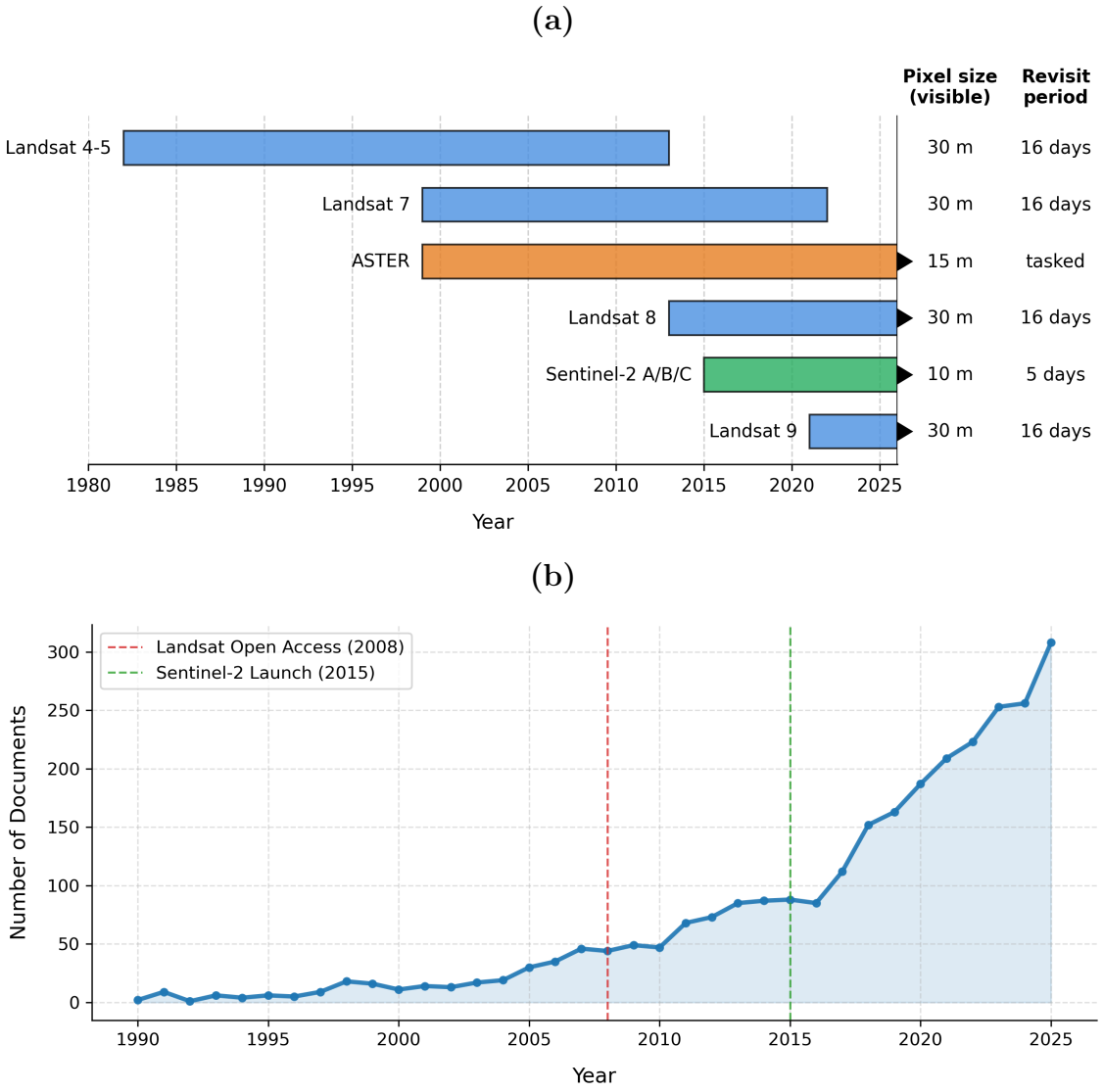


Figure 2.2: (a) Timeline for the publicly available satellites with global coverage. Source: Own elaboration, adapted and updated from Vos et al. (2019a). (b) Rapid evolution of the number of publications on satellite-derived shorelines (Number of documents per year for documents that include keywords "satellite" AND "shoreline" in Scopus database).

To leverage this massive and continuously expanding volume of "Big Data", the scientific community recognized that manual shoreline delineation was virtually impossible. This necessitated the development of automated computational frameworks designed to extract shoreline positions efficiently. Notable examples include CoastSat (Vos et al., 2019b), CASSIE (Almeida et al., 2021), and SHOREX (Sánchez-García et al., 2020). While differing in their specific implementations, these tools generally share a common processing pipeline: automated image acquisition via cloud APIs (like Google Earth Engine), cloud and cloud-shadow masking, initial water/land segmentation at the pixel level using spectral indices, and finally, subpixel contouring techniques to delineate the final, continuous shoreline vector.

2.4 Traditional Waterline Extraction via Spectral Indices

The critical step in traditional SDW extraction pipelines is the initial segmentation of the image into "water" and "non-water" classes. This is almost universally achieved using Spectral Water Indices. These indices exploit the characteristic of water to absorb most radiation in the Near-Infrared (NIR) and Shortwave-Infrared (SWIR) wavelengths, while land (soil, sand, and vegetation) strongly reflects them (see Figure 2.3).

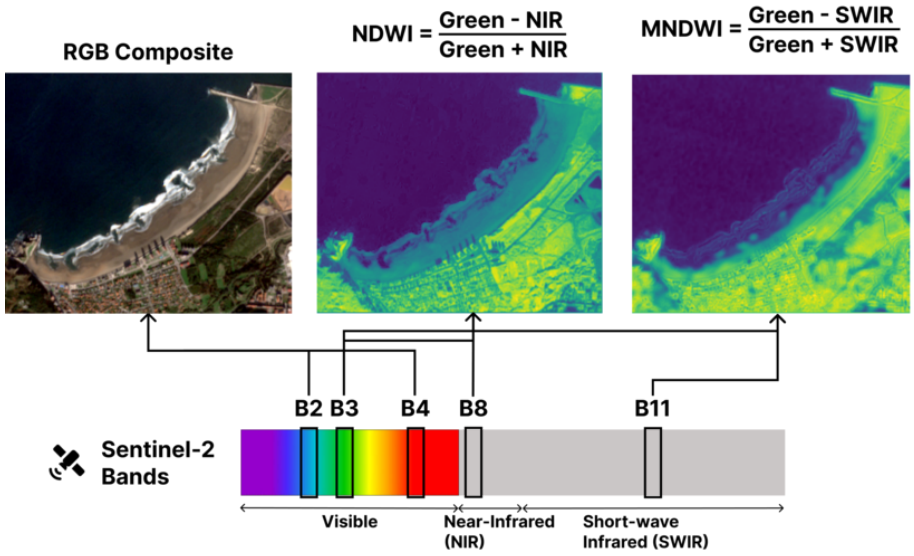


Figure 2.3: Schematic diagram of spectral index calculations using Sentinel-2 bands.

Historically, the Normalized Difference Water Index (NDWI), proposed by McFeeters (1996), and its variant, the Modified Normalized Difference Water Index (MNDWI) introduced by Xu (2006), have been the standard tools for this task. Their implementation has been extensively documented in scientific literature to track long-term shoreline evolution and morphological changes across diverse coastal settings. For instance Ghosh et al. (2015), Liu et al. (2017) or Wang et al. (2017) demonstrated the efficacy of these indices in achieving high-accuracy shoreline detection using medium resolution satellite imagery, proving their value for multi-decadal coastal monitoring.

More recently, indices designed specifically to suppress environmental noise and improve performance in complex coastal scenes have been introduced. These include the Automated Water Extraction Index (AWEI), developed by Feyisa et al. (2014) to enhance water shadows and urban background removal, and the Subtractive Coastal Water Index (SCoWI) (Bergsma et al., 2024). The latter is particularly relevant to this project as it was developed specifically for Sentinel-2 imagery and has shown promising results in macrotidal environments.

Once the index is calculated to create a greyscale intensity map, a threshold must be applied to binarize the image. While setting a constant threshold (e.g., zero) is common, adaptive statistical methods like Otsu's thresholding (Otsu, 1979) are frequently used to find the optimal separation value based on the image's histogram distribution. After binarization, the shoreline

is extracted by identifying the boundary between water and land pixels. This is typically done by finding the transition pixels between the two classes, which are then smoothed and converted into a vector line via subpixel contouring algorithms (such as marching-squares, Lorensen and Cline, 1987).

2.5 Challenges and Limitations in Macrotidal Environments

While traditional spectral indices combined with automated thresholding (e.g., Otsu) perform highly accurately (often achieving sub-pixel precision of <10 m) in microtidal, sheltered, or steeply sloped beaches, their reliability significantly degrades in complex, high-energy, and macrotidal environments. Recent global benchmarking efforts (Vos et al., 2023) have quantified this degradation, showing that horizontal extraction errors more than double (exceeding 20-40 m) on macrotidal beaches compared to their microtidal counterparts. Furthermore, site-specific assessments across the European Atlantic coast have similarly revealed profound limitations in these segmentation techniques during challenging oceanographic conditions (Cabezas-Rabadán et al., 2026).

The primary driver of error in these settings is the extensive and topographically complex intertidal zone exposed during ebb and low tides. In macrotidal beaches (tidal ranges > 4 m) characterized by intermediate or dissipative morphodynamic states, the retreating tide leaves behind vast plains of saturated sand. Spectrally, the transition from dry sand to wet sand to shallow water is not a sharp boundary but a gradual continuum. Indices such as MNDWI and AWEInsh consistently fail to differentiate between shallow water and saturated soil, systematically misclassifying the wet intertidal zone as "water" (see an example in Figure 2.4). This results in the extraction algorithms delineating the upper limit of the wet beach (or even the dune vegetation line) rather than the instantaneous water level, creating massive landward biases that can exceed hundreds of meters.

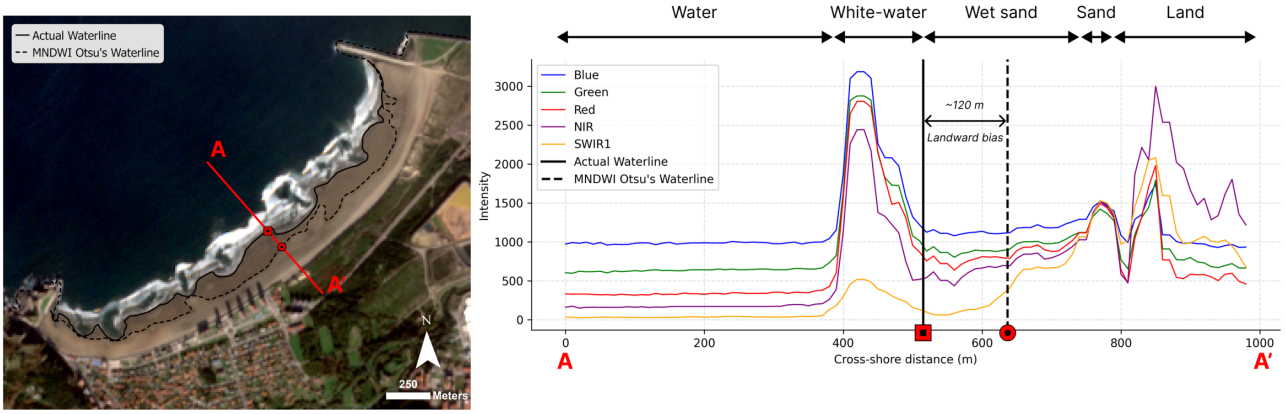


Figure 2.4: Cross-section of a macrotidal beach showing the spectral signature of water, white-water, wet sand, sand and land, derived from a Sentinel-2 image. The dashed line represents the shoreline extracted using MNDWI and Otsu's thresholding method, whereas the solid line represents the actual waterline. The MNDWI index is not able to differentiate between wet sand and water, leading to a landward bias in the extracted shoreline up to 120 m.

Furthermore, high-energy wave conditions may introduce additional errors. The presence of extensive white foam generated by breaking waves offshore drastically alters the expected low reflectance of the water surface. Indices like NDWI are particularly sensitive to foam, occasionally mistaking the outer breaker zone for land, thus producing severe seaward offsets (Hagenaars et al., 2018; Cabezas-Rabadán et al., 2026).

Ultimately, both specific case studies (Cabezas-Rabadán et al., 2026) and comprehensive benchmarking exercises (Vos et al., 2023) concur that the primary bottleneck for accurate SDW extraction in complex areas is not the geometric subpixel refinement algorithm, but the initial binary segmentation step (the spectral index determination and thresholding method) itself. Relying solely on the radiometric intensity of isolated pixels is insufficient to navigate the semantic ambiguity between wave foam, wet sand, and the actual waterline. This critical limitation strongly motivates the need to take a step back from classical spectral approaches and explore advanced, context-aware Deep Learning solutions.

2.6 The Shift towards Deep Learning in Earth Observation

To overcome the inherent limitations of pixel-by-pixel spectral thresholding, the remote sensing community is increasingly turning to Deep Learning (DL). Unlike traditional index thresholds that evaluate the reflectance value of an isolated pixel, advanced DL semantic segmentation architectures learn hierarchical spatial features by evaluating the spatial context, textures, and structural patterns. This contextual awareness allows models to distinguish the texture of wave foam from dry sand or recognize the spatial gradient of a saturated beach face, even when spectral signatures are nearly identical.

While the field is rapidly evolving, the technical landscape of DL for coastal monitoring is characterized by several competing paradigms. The encoder-decoder framework, exemplified by U-Net (Ronneberger et al., 2015) and its variants, remains the most prevalent architecture due to its effective use of skip connections to preserve fine spatial details (Tsiakos and Chalkias, 2023). More advanced convolutional models, such as DeepLabV3+ (Chen et al., 2018), have shown great potential by explicitly evaluating the image at multiple scales simultaneously. This wider field of view allows the model to better understand the broader coastal context (like the general geometry of the beach) while focusing sharply on the exact boundary, making it highly beneficial for extracting continuous, uninterrupted waterlines even in complex coasts.

Furthermore, a significant shift toward Vision Transformers (ViT) and hybrid architectures is underway. Models like SegFormer (Xie et al., 2021) and SETR (Zheng et al., 2020) demonstrate a superior ability to incorporate global contextual information, which is critical for distinguishing water boundaries in scenes affected by intense wave splash and structural shadows. More recently, dual-branch architectures such as TCCFNet (Fu et al., 2025) have emerged as highly synergistic networks, combining CNN layers for fine, local details with Transformer layers for large-scale scene understanding. Although TCCFNet was originally designed for mapping complex mangrove forests rather than strictly for shoreline extraction, its underlying mechanics are transferable to waterline mapping. By leveraging global context to understand the broader beach morphology while using local features to precisely trace the tricky land-water interface, this hybrid approach can drastically reduce the semantic confusion between visually similar elements like shallow water and wet sand. To push this focus on the transition zone even further, specialized boundary-aware networks (such as BS-Net (Jing et al., 2021) and BAWS (Zhan et al., 2025)) have been developed to treat the land-water interface as a primary feature rather than just the edge of a mask. By assigning dedicated interaction modules to explicitly model the boundary itself, these networks guarantee the high metric precision necessary for operational coastal monitoring.

Despite these architectural advancements, a critical analysis of the current state of the art reveals fundamental methodological gaps that this study aims to address:

- **Transition from Basic ML to Deep Contextual Learning:** While earlier AI applications for shoreline extraction heavily relied on traditional, pixel-wise Machine Learning classifiers (such as Support Vector Machines, Random Forests, or K-Nearest Neighbors), these methods still struggle with the complex spectral mixtures found in dynamic coastal zones (Tsiakos and Chalkias, 2023). Modern Deep Learning architectures overcome this by evaluating the spatial context rather than isolated pixels, though their full potential in adverse conditions is yet to be systematically quantified.
- **The Macrotidal Gap:** Most DL studies for shoreline extraction have been trained and validated in microtidal or sheltered environments where the land-water boundary is relatively stable. In macrotidal coasts, the "semantic ambiguity" between breaking wave foam, saturated sand, and shallow water remains a systematic challenge that most current models treat as noise rather than learned features (Tian et al., 2024). The effectiveness of DL models to navigate these specific, high-energy conditions is a critical void in current research.

- **Lack of Systematic Benchmarking vs. Operational Spectral Tools:** Although tools like CoastSat, CASSIE or SHOREX (which rely on spectral indices and automatic thresholding) are the current operational standard for automated shoreline extraction, there is a striking absence of extensive, consistent benchmarking that formally compares these traditional pipelines against modern semantic segmentation models (Tian et al., 2024). Most DL studies evaluate new architectures against other neural networks rather than quantifying the exact magnitude of improvement over index-based methods in challenging environments.
- **Architectural Over-reliance and Class Complexity**: Current literature shows an over-reliance on U-Net variants without systematic justification for more complex coastal scenes (Tian et al., 2024). Furthermore, most models still approach the problem as a binary classification (water vs. land), failing to exploit the potential of multi-class segmentation (e.g., explicitly labeling "wet sand" or "white water") to reduce the confusion that leads to landward or seaward biases.

By presenting a direct, data-driven comparison of classical spectral thresholding and modern semantic segmentation models (specifically optimized for multi-class detection in macrotidal settings), this project directly targets these gaps. It seeks not only to improve accuracy but to provide a rigorous assessment of whether AI-based workflows offer a justifiable operational advantage over established index-based monitoring tools.

Chapter 3

Materials and Methods

3.1 Study Areas

The study focuses on two beaches located on the northern coast of Spain: Salinas (Asturias) and El Puntal (Cantabria) (Figure 3.1).

Salinas is a 2.5 km embayed sandy beach system located on the left bank of the Avilés estuarine inlet (Asturias). The beach is bounded by the inlet jetty to the east and a rocky headland (La Peñona) to the west. Its western sector, adjacent to the urban area of Salinas, is backed by a seawall and promenade, while the eastern sector (El Espartal) preserves a natural dune field rising up to 15 m above mean sea level. The beach is characterized by a wide intertidal zone (up to 300 m at spring tides) and a mean tidal range of 4.5 m, classifying it as a macrotidal environment. The wave climate is predominantly energetic and approach from the northwest, impacting directly with mean significant wave heights around 1 m and frequent storm events that can exceed 4 m. The sand often shows dark patches due to the accumulation of coal and carbonaceous shales, which can further complicate spectral differentiation between wet sand and water.

El Puntal is a 4 km sandy spit at the entrance of Santander Bay (Cantabria), formed by the interaction of estuarine and marine dynamics. The beach is backed by a dune system that reaches up to 10 m high and 50–100 m wide. In the same way as Salinas, El Puntal experiences a wide intertidal zone (up to 250 m) and a mean tidal range of around 4 m. However, unlike Salinas, El Puntal does not receive direct wave impact, as it is protected by the Magdalena Peninsula. Furthermore, also in contrast to Salinas, El Puntal features a much less dark, golden-colored sand.

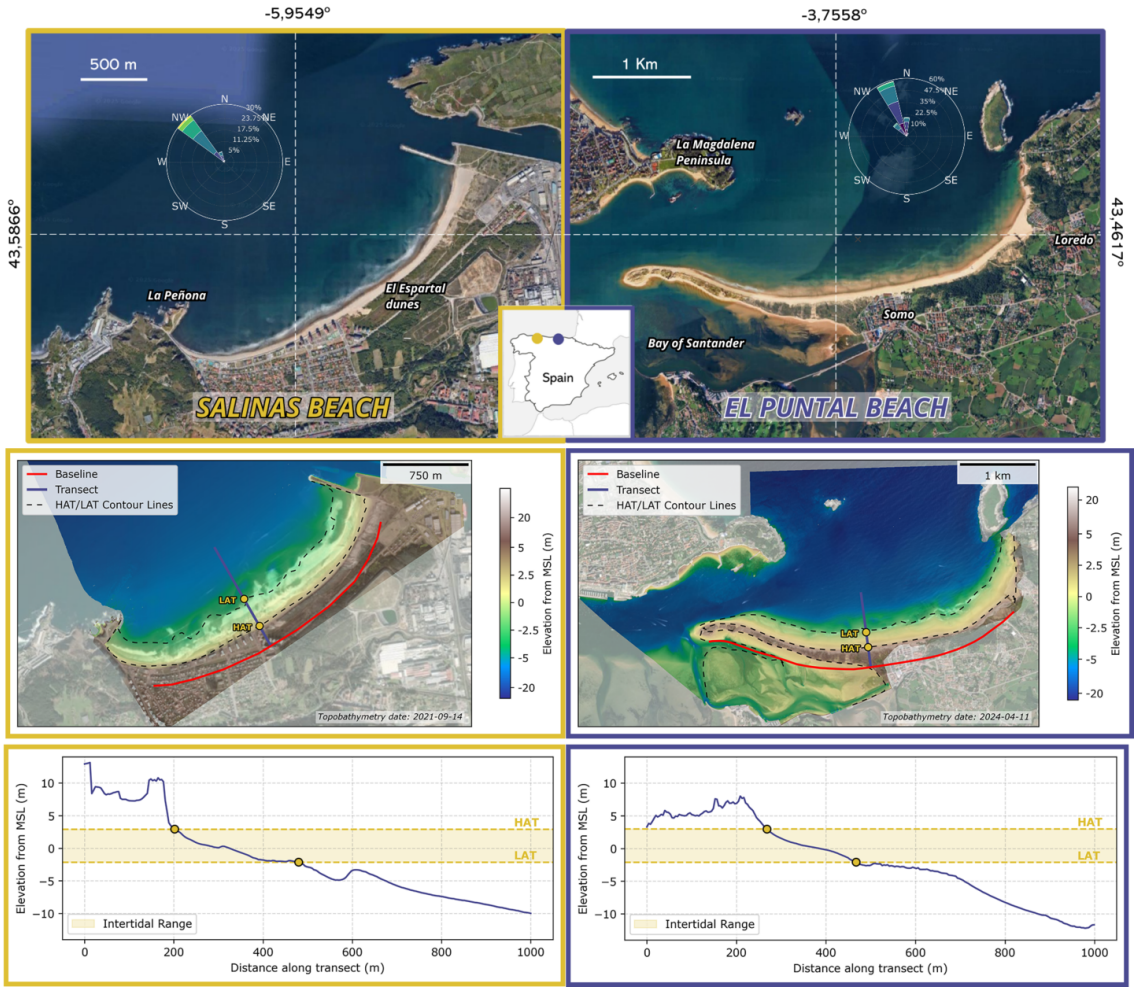


Figure 3.1: Location of the study sites: Salinas (left) and El Puntal (right) beaches. RGB image (top), topobathymetry (middle) using the ETRS89 / UTM 30N coordinate system, and beach profile (bottom) highlighting the intertidal range defined by the HAT/LAT (Highest/Lowest Astronomical Tide). (Source: Cabezas-Rabadán et al., 2026)

The selection of Salinas and El Puntal as study areas responds to their representativeness of highly dynamic macrotidal environments, which consistently pose the most significant challenges for automated shoreline extraction methodologies. Both beaches share practically identical macrotidal ranges, featuring extensive intertidal zones that undergo profound daily fluctuations and result in the recurrent exposure of vast stretches of saturated sand. This inherently generates a critical spectral ambiguity between shallow water and wet sand, severely penalizing traditional pixel-by-pixel segmentation indices.

However, while they share this macrotidal nature, they exhibit key differences that allow for a comprehensive evaluation of the models under varying degrees of complexity. El Puntal, being sheltered from direct wave impact, serves as a baseline scenario with standard, golden-colored sand. In stark contrast, Salinas is fully exposed to energetic wave climates, resulting in a significantly higher presence of breaking wave foam (white-water) across a wide surf zone.

Furthermore, the frequent accumulation of coal and carbonaceous shales along its intertidal profile creates noticeably dark patches of saturated sand. This stark color closely mimics the inherently low reflectance signature of water bodies in optical satellite imagery. Together, the excessive foam and the deceptively dark wet sand render Salinas an ideal stress-test. It provides a robust framework to critically evaluate whether Deep Learning architectures can successfully leverage spatial and structural context to differentiate the actual waterline, overcoming the limitations where traditional spectral methods typically fail.

3.2 Data Acquisition and Preprocessing

An initial dataset of freely available Sentinel-2 Level-2A imagery, spanning the period from 2015 to 2025, was acquired for both study areas. The imagery was downloaded using the Python API for the Google Earth Engine. To ensure optimal visibility of the coastal features, an initial filtering process was applied to download only cloud-free scenes.

From the available multispectral data, six specific bands were selected to provide the necessary radiometric information for both the derivation of spectral indices and the feature extraction in Deep Learning models: Red (B04), Green (B03), Blue (B02), Near-Infrared (B08), Shortwave-Infrared 1 (B11), and Shortwave-Infrared 2 (B12).

Following the data acquisition, a dedicated preprocessing pipeline was implemented. First, the original massive satellite tiles were spatially cropped to strictly encompass the defined Regions of Interest (ROIs) for Salinas and El Puntal. Second, given that Sentinel-2 bands possess varying native spatial resolutions, spatial homogenization was required. The SWIR 1 and SWIR 2 bands, natively captured at a 20 m resolution, were resampled to match the 10 m spatial resolution of the visible and NIR bands. Finally, to prepare the dataset for the subsequent training phase of the Deep Learning semantic segmentation models (see Section 3.5), the preprocessed image ROIs were systematically divided into smaller patches of 128×128 pixels.

3.3 Ground Truth Generation (Reference Datasets)

To rigorously train the algorithms and benchmark their performance, two distinct sets of Ground Truth (GT) data were generated: pixel-wise multi-class masks for the semantic segmentation models, and continuous vector lines for the final geometric benchmarking evaluation with spectral-index-based methods.

3.3.1 Coastal Mask Classes

To train and validate the Deep Learning models, a highly accurate pixel-level GT dataset was created. Given the complexity of the selected macrotidal environments, a multi-class approach was adopted rather than a simple binary (water/land) classification. The predefined classes

were: *water* (undisturbed water bodies), *white-water* (breaking wave foam in the surf zone), *wet sand* (the saturated intertidal zone), and *sand* (dry beach).

The annotation process was performed manually via photo-interpretation using the DigitalSreeni Image Annotator toolkit (Bhattiprolu, 2026) (Figure 3.2). To ensure the models focus solely on the relevant coastal features, any pixel not manually assigned to one of these four categories was automatically designated as an *ignore_index*. This ensures that background elements (like urban infrastructure or vegetation) do not interfere with the loss function calculation during training. In total, a dataset comprising 161 image patches (combined from Salinas and El Puntal) was manually annotated and exported into the standardized COCO JSON format.

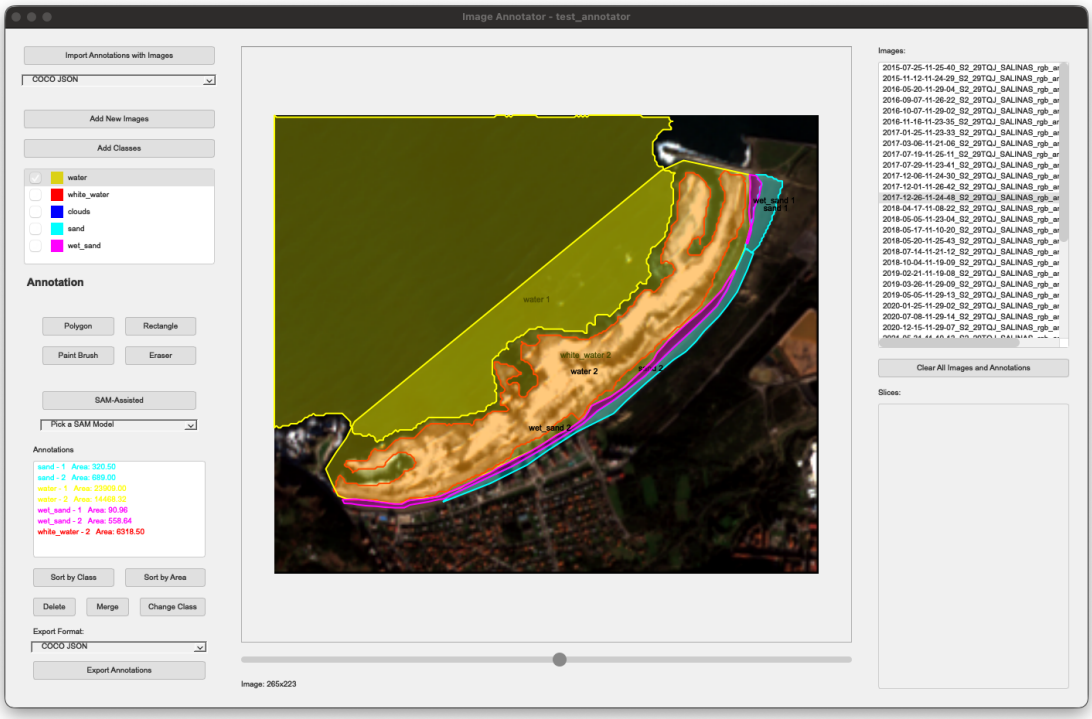


Figure 3.2: Screenshot of the DigitalSreeni Image Annotator software interface (Salinas beach). The overlaid mask displays the four annotated classes: water (yellow), white-water (red), wet sand (purple), and sand (cyan).

3.3.2 Waterline Vectorization

Alongside the pixel-wise masks, a separate reference dataset consisting of continuous vectorial waterlines was required to evaluate the geometric precision of the shorelines extracted by both the traditional indices and the DL models. For this purpose, a total of 285 reference waterlines (combined from Salinas and El Puntal) were generated.

This process was carried out using the geographic information system software ArcGIS Pro. The instantaneous waterline was manually digitized by tracing the spatial interface between the water mass and the emerged beach. The preprocessed 10 m resolution Sentinel-2 RGB

composites were utilized as the visual background reference for this task. The resulting vector lines were then exported as standard Shapefiles (.shp), establishing the absolute geometric Ground Truth for the final benchmarking phase.

3.4 Traditional Baseline: Spectral Indices and Thresholding

To establish a solid comparative baseline, we evaluated the performance of four different spectral water indices, coupled with three distinct thresholding techniques. This approach replicates the traditional operational pipelines currently dominating satellite-derived shoreline extraction.

3.4.1 Spectral Water Indices

Spectral indices are mathematical operations applied pixel-by-pixel across the different multispectral bands. By exploiting the distinct reflectance signatures of water and land, they heighten the contrast to facilitate water segmentation. We calculated four indices using the preprocessed Sentinel-2 bands: ρ_{Blue} (B02), ρ_{Green} (B03), ρ_{NIR} (B08), ρ_{SWIR1} (B11), and ρ_{SWIR2} (B12).

1. **Normalized Difference Water Index (NDWI):** Developed by McFeeters (1996), it maximizes the typical reflectance of water in the green light while minimizing its low reflectance in the near-infrared (NIR).

$$NDWI = \frac{\rho_{Green} - \rho_{NIR}}{\rho_{Green} + \rho_{NIR}} \tag{3.1}$$

2. **Modified Normalized Difference Water Index (MNDWI):** Proposed by Xu (2006) to address NDWI's difficulty in distinguishing water from built-up land. It replaces the NIR band with the Shortwave-Infrared (SWIR) band, which can penetrate shallow waters and wet environments slightly differently.

$$MNDWI = \frac{\rho_{Green} - \rho_{SWIR1}}{\rho_{Green} + \rho_{SWIR1}} \tag{3.2}$$

3. **Automated Water Extraction Index – No Shadows (AWEInsh):** Formulated by Feyisa et al. (2014) to maximize the separability of water from dark surfaces or topographic shadows. It combines multiple bands to suppress background noise.

$$AWEInsh = 4 \times (\rho_{Green} - \rho_{SWIR1}) - (0.25 \times \rho_{NIR} + 2.75 \times \rho_{SWIR2}) \tag{3.3}$$

4. **Subtractive Coastal Water Index (SCoWI):** Recently introduced by Bergsma et al. (2024) specifically for coastal applications with Sentinel-2 data. Unlike normalized ratios, it relies on a subtractive combination designed to better resolve dynamic intertidal zones and suppress the noise from wave breaking foam in macrotidal coasts.

$$SCoWI = \rho_{Blue} + 2 \times (\rho_{Green} - \rho_{NIR}) - 0.75 \times \rho_{SWIR1} - 0.5 \times \rho_{SWIR2} \tag{3.4}$$

3.4.2 Thresholding Techniques

Once the spectral indices are calculated, creating continuous unbouded greyscale intensity maps, a binarization process is required to extract the definitive land-water masks. This is achieved by applying a definitive cutoff threshold. To comprehensively benchmark this step, three different thresholding techniques were evaluated across all indices:

1. **Zero Thresholding:** A static approach fundamentally embedded in the original formulation of normalizated and subtractive water indices. Theoretically, water strongly absorbs NIR/SWIR light, rendering its ratio positive (> 0), while highly reflective land surfaces yield negative values (< 0). This method assumes a theoretical zero value as the universal boundary.

2. **Otsu's Thresholding:** A dynamic, image-adaptive algorithm widely established as the operational standard in modern extraction pipelines. Otsu (1979) method automatically determines the optimal threshold by calculating the value that minimizes the intra-class variance of the image's histogram under the assumption of a bimodal distribution (distinct water and land classes).

3. **Modified Otsu (Local Minimum Histogram):** Because standard Otsu thresholding can be mathematically skewed by disproportionate land/water class distributions or noisy elements unique to macrotidal beaches (like extensive wet sand patches dragging the histogram), we also evaluated a robust refinement proposed by Bergsma et al. (2024). In this modified approach, once the original Otsu threshold is calculated, the algorithm defines a search interval between the two nearest local maxima on either side of the threshold. The definitive binarization cutoff is then set to the absolute local minimum of the histogram within that specific interval. This adjustment aims to physically anchor the threshold exactly in the valley between the two class distributions, ensuring a more context-aware segmentation.

3.5 Deep Learning Semantic Segmentation

3.5.1 Model Architectures

3.5.2 Encoders

3.5.3 Training Setup

3.6 Waterline Extraction Pipeline

3.7 Evaluation Methodology

3.7.1 Pixel-based Evaluation

3.7.2 Geometric Evaluation

Chapter 4

Results

TO BE WRITTEN

Detail in this section the results obtained using the methodology described in the previous section.

Chapter 5

Conclusions and Future Works

TO BE WRITTEN

This chapter must include:

- A description of the conclusions of the work:
  - Once the results have been obtained, what conclusions are drawn?
  - Are these results as expected? Or have they been amazing? Why?
- A critical reflection on the achievement of the objectives initially set:
  - Have we achieved all the objectives? If the answer is negative, why?
- A critical analysis of the monitoring of planning and methodology throughout the product:
  - Has the schedule been followed?
  - Has the planned methodology been adequate enough?
  - Has it been necessary to introduce changes to ensure the success of the work? Why?
- From the impacts foreseen in 1.3, ethical-social, sustainability and diversity, evaluate/mention whether they have been mitigated (if they were negative) or whether they have been achieved (if they were positive).
- If unforeseen impacts have appeared in 1.3, evaluate/mention how they have mitigated (if they were negative) or what they have contributed (if they were positive).
- The future lines of work that have not been explored in this work and have remained pending.

Chapter 6

Glossary

TO BE WRITTEN

Definition of the most relevant terms and acronyms used in the Report.

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List of sections that are too extensive to include in memory and have a self-contained character (e.g. user manuals, installation manuals, etc.)

Depending on the type of work, there may be no need to add an annex.